LESSON NOTES

Absolute Beginner Questions Answered by Hiroko #15 ONEGAI SHIMASU or KUDASAI?

CONTENTS

2 Grammar

15

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GRAMMAR

Q: What's the difference between *ONEGAI SHIMASU* and *KUDASAI*?

Both ***kudasai*** and ***onegai shimasu*** are used when making a request for items. However, there are some differences between the two.

Language Tip

- ***Kudasai*** follows the object and the particle *o*, like ***mizu o kudasai*** which means "water, please."
- ***Onegai shimasu*** can be replaced with ***kudasai*** when you want an object. It sounds a little more polite than using ***kudasai***. So you can say, ***mizu o onegai shimasu*** in more formal situations.
- However, there are some situations when only ***onegai shimasu*** or ***kudasai*** is used.

For *onegai shimasu*:

- First, when you are **making a request for service**. For example, when you ask a taxi driver to drive to Shinjuku station, you should say *shinjuku eki made onegai shimasu*.
- Second, when you are **asking for someone on the phone**. For example, you would like to talk to Tomoko on the phone. However, her father answers. In this case you have to say *Tomoko san o onegai shimasu.*
- **PLEASE BE CAREFUL.** If you say, *Tomoko-san o kudasai*, instead, it sounds like a proposal of marriage, like "do you allow me to marry Tomoko?"

For *kudasai*:

- For **making requests that involve an action**, you need to use ***kudasai* after the *te*-form of the verb.** *Onegaishimasu* cannot be used in this case. For example, ***matte kudasai*** which means "please wait."